

CHE 427 (Engineering and Entrepreneurship)
Department of Chemical Engineering
University of Illinois Chicago
Fall 2025

Quiz 2
November 12, 2025

The following companies managed to leverage their intellectual portfolio (i.e. license, sell, or partner with) to build a successful business model. Discuss briefly each case and highlight their path to success:

1) Pfizer:

Pfizer has built its success by using its strong patent portfolio and forming smart partnerships. Instead of only relying on in-house research, the company often works with smaller biotech firms to access new ideas and share development risks. A great example is its collaboration with BioNTech to create the COVID-19 vaccine. BioNTech brought the mRNA technology, while Pfizer handled clinical testing, manufacturing, and global distribution. This partnership showed how Pfizer uses licensing and joint ventures to move innovations from the lab to the market faster, strengthening both its brand and business model.

2) Spotify:

Spotify's success came from how it licensed music rather than owning it. By signing deals with major record labels and publishers, Spotify gained legal access to a massive music library while focusing on improving its streaming technology. Its algorithms and data analysis tools personalize playlists and keep users engaged, which became key intellectual assets for the company. Through partnerships with artists, labels, and advertisers, Spotify turned streaming into a sustainable business model that benefits both listeners and the music industry.

3) Uber:

Uber's success mostly comes from its technology, not from owning cars. Its app uses location data and algorithms to match drivers and riders efficiently and to set prices dynamically based on demand. Uber's intellectual property lies in its software, data systems, and brand reputation. The company also expands through partnerships—like teaming up with car rental services, fuel card providers, and restaurants for Uber Eats—which helps it grow across different markets. By combining its platform technology with strategic collaborations, Uber created a flexible and scalable model for on-demand services.